

Solar airplane flies through the night

An experimental, solar-powered aircraft, whose makers envision a flight around the world using only energy collected from the sun, successfully completed a 26-hour test flight recently. Powered by 12,000 solar cells and sunlight-powered lithium batteries, the plane landed safely in Switzerland after flying through the night. The prototype even exceeded the 8500 metres that were intended and reached an altitude of 8700 metres. With the help of 12,000 solar panels built into its enormous 63.4m wing, its 400 kg of batteries were fully charged during this long ascent. The goal of the project is to have a solar-powered plane flying day and night without fuel.

The Solar Impulse HB-SIA weighs 1600 kg and is powered by four electric motors that save energy from its solar cells during the day.

Turn any surface into a touchscreen

So far touchscreens have been limited to mobile computing devices such as smartphones and tablet computers. But that won't be the case in the near future. Researchers at Intel are working on a project that uses real-time 3-D object recognition to turn any surface into a touchscreen. Thus an ordinary coffee table in your living room could morph into a touchscreen when you put a finger on it, and show a menu of music and video to choose from.

Some companies are already trying to expand the use of touchscreens. For instance, Display, based in Portugal, can turn any surface—flat or curved—into a touch-sensitive display by sticking a thinner-than-paper



The Solar Impulse HB-SIA solar-powered aircraft

polymer film on that surface to make it interactive.

Intel research labs try to do away with the extra layer. Instead, they have created a rig with two cameras, one to capture the image of the objects and the other to capture depth. The depth cameras help recognise the objects and the difference between the hand touching the table or hovering over it. A pico-projector helps beam the virtual menus. The cameras and the pico-projector can be combined into devices just a little bigger than your cellphone. Put a few of these in different rooms and point them on tables, and the system is ready to go.

At that point, the software program kicks in. The program, which can run on any computer anywhere in the house, helps identify objects accurately and create the virtual menus.

Google search without searching

According to Amit Singhal, one of Google's veteran search algorithm engineers, 'search without searching' is the future of search. He explains that the components are all there to offer us the

right information at the right place and time, without the need to search for it.

Said Singhal, "What we have today is these wonderful components; my calendar is on the cloud, my calendar knows that after I am done here today I will have dinner with my family, my calendar also knows my to-do list.

"One of the things on my to-do list is to buy a cricket bat because my old one is going dry.

"So my calendar knows when I have free time, my (GPS-enabled) phone knows where I am, my to-do list has a list of things I need to accomplish and time is expensive.

"On top of that Google local knows the map of this place and it knows where all the sports shops are. So why can't this thing tell me "you have 45 minutes free in your agenda, there's a sports shop 300 metres away, go and buy a cricket bat."

Funny translator

Funny Translator is a rapidly-growing Web project by two New York City-based Translation Services USA, a major translation agency, and the programmers of ConveyThis, an on-the-fly

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info@sparshsecuritech.com | www.sparshsecuritech.com

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